

Word family: **history / histories / historical / historic / historically / historian**

Base word: history

Plural: histories

Related forms: historical, historic, historically, historian

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective-related forms (相關形容詞) / person noun (人物名詞)

Your sentence:

> “For example, he once spent fifteen minutes explaining why old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a **history textbook**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **history** means the **study and organized understanding of events, people, societies, and developments from the past**.

A **history textbook** is therefore a school or academic book used to teach this subject.

繁體中文：**研究和記錄過去的人物、事件、社會及其發展過程的學科**

中文翻譯：

> “...old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a **history textbook**.”

「.....舊電車路線比一本**歷史教科書**更能告訴你一座城市的故事。」

Here:

history textbook = 用來教授和學習過去事件、人物及社會發展的歷史科教科書

1. **history** = academic subject/study of the past (學科) — 歷史 ; 歷史學

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: The subject or field that studies and interprets events, people, societies, and changes from the past.

Practice 1 — Original

> “Old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a **history textbook**.”

「舊電車路線比**歷史教科書**更能告訴你一座城市的故事。」

Practice 2

> “She studied **history** at university.”

「她在大學修讀**歷史 / 歷史學**。」

Practice 3

> “**History** was my favourite subject at school.”

「**歷史科**是我在學校最喜歡的科目。」

history = 研究、整理及解釋過去人物、事件、社會和發展的學科

Common:

- * study history
- * history teacher
- * history lesson
- * history textbook
- * history department

These are one underlying **academic subject** sense.

2. **history** = events and developments of the past (過去發生的事情) — 歷史 ; 過去的發展

Here, **history** means the actual events that happened in the past, rather than the academic study of them.

Practice 4

> “The building has played an important role in the city’s **history**.”

「這座建築在城市的**歷史發展**中扮演了重要角色。」

Practice 5

> “This was one of the most difficult periods in the country’s **history**.”

「這是該國**歷史上**最艱難的時期之一。」

history = 某個國家、地方、組織或人類社會在過去真正發生過的事件及發展過程

Compare:

> “She studies **history**.”

= 她修讀歷史這門學科。

> “The city has a long **history**.”

= 這座城市有很長的歷史發展。

These require different mental concepts:

study of the past versus **the past events themselves**.

3. **a history of + subject/place/person** (記述 / 發展紀錄) —的歷史；歷史記述

History can also mean a **written or organized account of how something developed over time**.

Practice 6

> “He wrote a **history of Hong Kong cinema**.”

「他寫了一部**香港電影史**。」

Practice 7

> “The book provides a short **history of the railway**.”

「這本書簡要介紹了這條鐵路的**發展歷史 / 歷史記述**。」

a history of something = 按時間或發展次序整理和記述某個主題過去情況的作品或記錄

This differs from Meaning 1:

> **history** = the academic subject

whereas:

> **a history of Hong Kong**

= a particular account or work describing Hong Kong's past.

This countable use is worth keeping separately.

4. **someone's history / a history of something (個人 / 機構背景) — 過往紀錄 ; 背景**

Here, **history** means the record of things that have happened to or been done by a particular person, organization, or thing.

Practice 8

> “The company has a long **history of innovation**.”

「這家公司有長期持續創新的**過往紀錄**。」

Practice 9

> “The police looked into his employment and financial **history**.”

「警方調查了他的就業及財務**過往紀錄 / 背景**。」

history = 某個人、機構或事物過去曾經發生、經歷或做過的事情所形成的背景和紀錄

Common:

- * employment history
- * credit history
- * criminal history
- * family history
- * relationship history

The object changes, but the underlying concept remains:

> **a record/background of previous events**

So these should not be split into separate lexical senses merely because the domain changes. This follows the Manual's merging rule.

5. **medical history (醫療背景) — 病歷 ; 過往健康紀錄**

A particularly important domain-specific version of Meaning 4 is **medical history**.

Practice 10

> “The doctor asked about her medical **history**.”

「醫生詢問她的**過往病歷 / 健康紀錄**。」

Practice 11

> “There is no family **history** of the disease.”

「這個家庭沒有這種疾病的**家族病史**。」

****medical history = 某人過往的疾病、治療、手術、藥物及其他健康相關情況的紀錄****

For database counting, I would ****merge this with Meaning 4****, because the underlying semantic concept is still:

> ****record of what happened previously****

The Chinese becomes ****病歷 / 病史****, but that contextual translation alone does not justify a new English lexical sense.

The Golden Manual specifically says domain differences should not create artificial meanings when the same broad definition still works.

6. ****history = stored record of previous activity (系統 / 科技) — 歷史紀錄 ; 操作紀錄****

In technology, ****history**** commonly means a stored list of previous actions, searches, visits, transactions, etc.

Practice 12

> “I cleared my browser ****history****.”

「我清除了瀏覽器的****瀏覽紀錄****。」

Practice 13

> “You can view your order ****history**** in the app.”

「你可以在應用程式中查看自己的****過往訂單紀錄****。」

****history = 系統按時間保存的過往活動、操作、搜尋、交易或瀏覽紀錄****

Common:

* browser history

- * search history
- * order history
- * transaction history
- * chat history
- * viewing history

This is closely related to the broader **past record** sense, but because it is extremely common in modern technology and has a distinctive learner interpretation, it is useful to show explicitly.

For core counting, though, I would merge it into Meaning 4 rather than inflate the semantic count.

7. **a history of + repeated problem/behaviour** (反覆過往情況) — 有.....的長期紀錄 / 慣常情況

A common construction is:

> **have a history of...**

This means something has happened repeatedly or characteristically in the past.

Practice 14

> “The building has a **history of electrical problems**.”

「這座大樓過去一直有**多次電力問題的紀錄**。」

Practice 15

> “He has a **history of arriving late**.”

「他過去一直有**經常遲到的紀錄 / 習慣**。」

have a history of something = 過去多次出現某種行為、問題或情況，形成一個持續可見的紀錄

This belongs to the same broader **past record/background** concept as Meaning 4.

Related form: **historical**

Historical primarily means **connected with history or the study/past record of history**.

historical = relating to the past/history (與歷史有關的) — 歷史的

Practice 16

> “The museum contains many **historical documents**.”

「博物館收藏了很多**歷史文獻**。」

Practice 17

> “The novel is based on **historical events**.”

「這本小說以真實的**歷史事件**為基礎。」

historical = 與過去事件、歷史研究或歷史資料有關的

Related form: **historic**

Historic has a different and important meaning.

It normally means:

> **important or influential in history**

Practice 18

> “The leaders reached a **historic agreement**.”

「各方領袖達成了一項具有重大歷史意義的**歷史性協議**。」

Practice 19

> “It was a **historic moment** for the country.”

「那是該國一個具有重大意義的**歷史性時刻**。」

historic = 因為非常重要、具突破性或影響深遠，而值得被歷史記錄的

This contrast deserves special attention.

Important distinction: **historical** vs **historic**

This is probably the most important family contrast.

historical

= connected with history/the past

> **historical documents**

= 歷史文獻

They are documents relating to past events.

historic

= historically important

> **a historic decision**

= 具有重大歷史意義的決定

So:

historical = 與歷史有關

historic = 重要得足以在歷史上留下紀錄

Not every historical event is **historic**.

Related form: **historically**

Historically means from the perspective of history, or traditionally in the past.

Practice 20

> “The area has **historically** been a centre of trade.”

「從歷史上看，這個地區一直是貿易中心。」

Practice 21

> “These two communities have **historically** had close ties.”

「這兩個社群**在歷史上一直**保持密切聯繫。」

historically = 從過往歷史情況來看；在歷史發展中

Related form: **historian**

A **historian** is someone who studies, researches, or writes about history professionally or academically.

Practice 22

> “The programme interviewed a local **historian**.”

「這個節目訪問了一位本地**歷史學家**。」

Practice 23

> “Several **historians** disagree about the causes of the conflict.”

「多位**歷史學家**對衝突成因有不同看法。」

historian = 專門研究、分析或撰寫歷史的人

Fixed expression: **make history** — 創造歷史

Meaning: To do something sufficiently important, new, or remarkable to be remembered historically.

Practice 24

> “She **made history** by becoming the first woman to hold the position.”

「她成為首位擔任這個職位的女性，因而**創造了歷史**。」

Practice 25

> “The team hopes to **make history** tonight.”

「球隊希望今晚能**創造歷史 / 創下歷史性成就**。」

make history = 做出重要或前所未有的事情，令該事件值得被後世記錄

This is a common fixed expression rather than another core meaning of bare **history**.

Fixed expression: **go down in history — 載入史冊**

Practice 26

> “The discovery will **go down in history**.”

「這項發現將會**載入史冊**。」

Practice 27

> “That speech went down in **history** as one of his most important.”

「那次演說**載入歷史**，成為他最重要的演說之一。」

****go down in history = 因具有重大或特別意義而長久被後人記住及記錄****

Again, this belongs in fixed expressions.

Fixed expression: **be history — 成為過去；完蛋 / 不再存在**

Informally, **history** can appear in:

> **be history**

meaning that something has ended, disappeared, or is no longer relevant.

Practice 28

> “Once the new system arrives, these old machines will be **history**.”

「新系統一到，這些舊機器就會**成為過去 / 被淘汰**。」

Practice 29

> “If the company loses that contract, it could be **history**.”

「如果公司失去那份合約，它可能就會**撐不下去 / 成為歷史**。」

****be history = 已經結束、不再存在、不再有用或不再重要；非正式****

This is a useful idiomatic extension, not a core literal meaning.

Important distinction: **history vs story**

These are commonly confused.

history

= actual past events, or the study/record of them

story

= an account or narrative, which may be true or fictional

> “the history of Hong Kong”

= 香港實際過去的發展

> “a story about Hong Kong”

= 一個關於香港的故事；可能是真實，也可能是虛構

So **history** normally carries a stronger connection to actual past events.

Important distinction: **history vs past**

the past

= the time before now

history

= past events considered as a record, development, or field of study

> “We cannot change the **past**.”

= 我們不能改變過去。

> “We study **history**.”

= 我們研究歷史。

The terms overlap, but **history** contains more of an idea of **events**, development, record, and interpretation.

Important distinction: **history vs background**

background

is broader.

It can include:

- * education
- * family
- * culture
- * experience
- * circumstances

history

focuses particularly on **what happened previously**.

> “his medical history”

= 他的過往健康 / 病歷紀錄

> “his medical background”

can be broader and may even refer to medical training or professional experience depending on context.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

- * **history**
- * **histories**
- * **historical**
- * **historic**
- * **historically**
- * **historian**

Useful compounds and expressions include:

- * **history textbook**
- * **history lesson**
- * **family history**

* **medical history**
 * **employment history**
 * **credit history**
 * **browser history**
 * **search history**
 * **make history**
 * **go down in history**

The crucial family contrast is:

****historical = connected with history****

versus

****historic = important in history****

The Golden Manual requires this type of confusing adjective contrast to be made explicit when it directly prevents learner error.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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history — academic subject 的學科	研究、整理和解釋過去人物、事件、社會及其發展
history — past events/development 的事件及發展過程	某個國家、地方、組織或社會在過去真正發生的事件及發展過程
a history of something — account 的作品或紀錄	按時間或發展次序整理並記述某個主題過去情況的作品或紀錄
someone/something's history — record/background 或做過的事情所形成的背景和紀錄	某個人、機構或事物過去曾發生、經歷或做過的事情所形成的背景和紀錄
medical/employment/browser/etc. history 「過往紀錄」的同一核心概念	某個特定範疇內過往事件或活動的紀錄；屬於「過往紀錄」的同一核心概念
historical	與歷史、過去事件或歷史研究資料有關的
historic	重要、突破性或影響深遠，足以在歷史上留下紀錄的
historically	從過往歷史情況來看；在歷史發展中
historian	專門研究、分析或撰寫歷史的人

For your original sentence

> “...old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a ****history textbook****.”

The exact meaning is:

****history = 研究及講述過去人物、事件、社會和發展的學科****

Therefore:

****history textbook = 用來教授和學習歷史這門學科的教科書****

So:

> ****a history textbook****

= ****一本歷史教科書****

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely distinct core meanings**** for ****history****:

1. ****the academic subject/study of the past****
2. ****the actual events and development of the past****
3. ****a written/organized account of a subject's past — a history of X****
4. ****the previous record/background of a person, organization, activity, system, etc.****

I would merge ****medical history, employment history, criminal history, browser history, search history, transaction history****, and ****a history of repeated behaviour/problems**** under #4 rather than artificially splitting them by domain. ****Make history, go down in history,**** and ****be history**** are useful fixed expressions rather than additional core meanings.